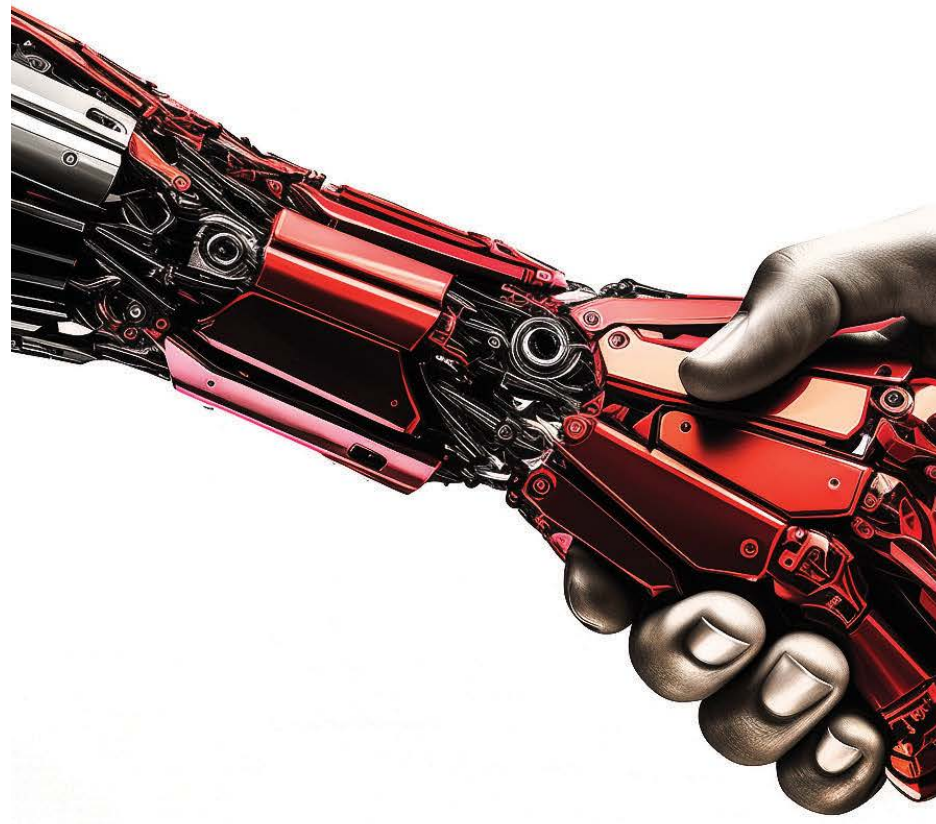


that there is adequate testing and oversight of these tools.

Otherwise, there is a risk that we shift responsibility downstream. The frontline health worker or the farmer to whom these tools are being introduced must not bear the burden of protecting themselves from harm. The tendency for automation bias also renders arguments around having a human in the loop a bit too simplistic. A recent study showed that a GPT-based tool not only fabricated the findings of a research paper but also the dataset on which the findings were based. Detecting this would be near-impossible even for the most experienced eye, let alone a frontline health worker or a farmer.

Beyond the Hype

Setting the narrative straight starts with cutting through the hype around AI. AI systems are far from resembling human intelligence. Rather, AI systems are better understood as a form of computational statistics that scan large quantities of data to detect patterns and provide probabilistic analysis or prediction. Consider the difference in how a child and an AI system learn. An AI system needs to be exposed to many thousands of images of a car and then detect patterns across those images to recognise subsequent cars. But a child can see just two to three cars to be able to recognise a car, even if it is missing a tyre or other distinguishing features. Understanding AI as a form of statistics must temper our view of its ability. Statistics models can be useful for many things but should not be considered the 'truth' or the basis for people's ability to exercise their rights and access critical social services.

AI also does not have any agentic properties—whether it produces socially beneficial outcomes will depend on how it is built, by whom, and for what purpose. The majority of AI development is currently driven by narrow commercial interests, with little regard for public interest. Changing the incentives and actors driving AI innovation—not advancement in AI itself—will be the key deciding factor in whether AI serves the public interest.

A RECENT STUDY SHOWED THAT A **GPT-BASED TOOL NOT ONLY FABRICATED THE FINDINGS OF A RESEARCH PAPER** BUT ALSO THE DATASET ON WHICH THE FINDINGS WERE BASED

Double Bind for the Global South

This presents a double bind for developing countries like India. On the one hand, there is a need to democratise AI development and ensure wider representation in the innovation processes. Countries like India are thus looking to bolster domestic champions through data governance policies that facilitate private actors to access public data. However, the recent explosion of AI is a result of a harmful and exploitative business model, one based on commercial surveillance or the unlawful collection and monetisation of individual data.

The speed of AI development is also made possible by the exploitation of cheap labour in the Global South. While AI may seem high-tech, it requires manual labelling and annotating of millions and millions of pieces of textual, audio and visual content. Technology companies outsource this to workers in the Global South—these workers are paid a pittance, have no rights and work in deplorable conditions. The environmental impacts of AI development must also be considered. For example, recent studies estimate that ChatGPT consumes 500ml of water for every five to 50 prompts answered.

The use of the term AI by technology companies legitimises this business model as advancing the frontiers

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS** / AI